



Reflexive AI

Focus group facilitation • volunteer-run

In-company Focus Group

A facilitation guide for running a focus group about reflexive AI in your organization.

// WHY THIS FOCUS GROUP

Uncover how your organization can use AI effectively, responsibly and in a human-centered way.

It gathers evidence for a shared framework — and gives people in your organization space to discuss what human-centered AI means for them.

Face-to-face, ~90 minutes

Best in person; adapts easily to online breakout rooms.

12–20 participants, 5 topics

A World Café across five stations, each moderated by a host.

PURPOSE OF THE STUDY

Help us uncover how organizations can use AI effectively, responsibly and human-centered.

A collaborative action research project run by volunteers to uncover how organizations can harness the power of AI effectively, responsibly and in a manner that empowers employees and teams.

reflexiveai.org • info@reflexiveai.org

About this guide

Thank you for contributing to the Reflexive AI Research Initiative. We are grateful for your time and effort.

This facilitation guide helps you run a focus group about reflexive AI in your organization. It provides invaluable data for our research initiative to build a framework for effective, responsible, human-centered AI. It also provides a good opportunity for people in your organization to reflect on what this means for them.

The focus group typically takes 90 minutes. We assume, and recommend, a face-to-face setting with 12-20 participants. But the format can be easily adapted to online settings with breakout rooms.

Because the focus group is part of a scientific study, it is important to:

- Ensure all participants are aware of this, and the (anonymous) results from the discussions will be shared with the research team.
- Avoid biasing participants by pushing them in a certain direction (i.e. "AI is great" or "AI is terrible").
- When you must modify the facilitation format, ensure that the informed consent form is filled in first, and that discussions are moderated by hosts. Please notify us of any changes you made.
- Information about the initiative can be found at reflexiveai.org.

Do you need some help or have open questions? Do you have feedback on this guide? Do not hesitate to contact the coordination team at info@reflexiveai.org.

How to prepare

How to invite people

- Clarify the aim of the focus group: to uncover how organizations can use AI effectively, responsibly and human-centered. Keep your invitation free from personal beliefs or bias.
- For the best outcomes, maximize the number of people with decision-making authority around AI.
- Emphasize that the discussion is part of a scientific study. Insights will be shared with the research initiative.

An example invitation is: "Artificial intelligence (AI) is changing our work and workplaces, which creates opportunities but also risks. I'd like to invite you to a 90-minute focus group where we think and consider how organizations – including ours – can use AI effectively, responsibly and in a human-centered manner. This is part of a global Reflexive AI Research Initiative, and our anonymous results will be shared with them. The questions we tackle will also help our own thinking about this in our organization. Your view and perspective and contribution are highly appreciated."

Materials

- Print the topic sheets (5 total).
- Print the station host protocol (5 total).
- Print the informed consent forms (1 per participant).
- Bring empty flips or whiteboards (10-20).
- Bring stickies, markers and pens.
- A timer is useful to track time.
- A buzzer or tingsha bell is useful to indicate new rounds.
- Optionally, bring snacks and drinks for a relaxed atmosphere.
- Optionally, name stickers or badges.

Practical preparation

- If you run this in a physical space, create five stations. This could be five tables with 4-6 chairs, five flipcharts or whiteboards. Ensure there is one topic sheet and one station host protocol at each station. Add markers, stickies, snacks and drinks.
- If you run this online, use our Miro template.
- Ideally, already pick five participants upfront to act as station hosts and ensure they've read the station host protocol.



5 min

Step 1. Welcome

Welcome the participants to the focus group. Thank them for making time to contribute. Introduce yourself.

Introduce the topic for this focus group; to explore what human-centered AI use looks like in your organization, and what can be done to ensure it.

It is important to keep this part short and free of bias. The next step is an opening exercise to get everyone's thinking started.



10 min

Step 2. Informed Consent

In this step, participants have the opportunity to give their consent to participating in a scientific study. Good research requires informed consent.

Steps

- Ask all participants to enter the informed consent form. If a person does not wish to consent, this is perfectly fine. However, they can not continue participating in the session.
- Collect the forms.



🕒 15 min

Step 3. Impromptu Networking

We begin the session with an opener to build connections and get our thinking started.

Steps

- Ask “What have you observed, noticed or wondered about how AI is used within our organization?”. Give participants 1 minute to reflect on this in silence.
- **5 min** Now, ask participants to form pairs and take 4 minutes to respond to the question. If you have an uneven number, one group will have three participants.
- **5 min** Now, ask participants to form new pairs, and again to take 4 minutes to respond to the question and build on the previous conversations.
- **5 min** Now, ask participants to form new pairs, and again to take 4 minutes to respond to the question and build on the previous conversations.
- Don’t debrief the discussions. The next exercise is ideal for this.



⌚ 60 min

Step 4: World Cafe

We use World Cafe as the primary format for the focus groups. We assume 12-20 participants. In this format, each participant discusses 3 out of 5 topics in small groups at different stations, each moderated by a host.

How to run

- Introduce the aim; to engage in multiple rounds of small-group discussions around 5 topics, each at a different station, and capture the output on sheets.
- Explain the general format. Participants will distribute evenly across the stations. There, a host facilitates a small-group discussion and records insights on a sheet. After 15 minutes, a new round starts and participants move to another station and a new topic.
- Invite participants to distribute evenly across the stations. If you did not pick hosts upfront, ask each small group to choose one of their own to act as host. The hosts facilitate and moderate the discussion, asking open questions while keeping their own opinions to themselves. Ensure that each group familiarizes themselves with the station host protocol.
- **15 min** Begin round 1 ("Discussion"). Invite the participants at each table to discuss their topic openly and collaboratively for 15 minutes. The hosts moderate the discussion, write down group insights and ensure that the host protocol is followed. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 2 ("Discussion"). Ask the participants to redistribute evenly across the stations, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite the participants to discuss their new topics with the station host, while they continue moderating the discussion and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **15 min** Begin round 3 ("Discussion"). Ask the participants to redistribute evenly across the stations, picking a station at random that they have not already visited. Invite the participants to discuss their new topics with the station host, while they continue moderating the discussion and adding insights to the sheet. Use the buzzer/bell at the end of the round.
- **20 min** Bring everyone together again and ensure everyone has a marker or a pen in hand. Ask the hosts to bring the sheets from their station. Ask a host to step forward and summarize the core insights from their table. When done, all participants (but the host) step forward to distribute three dots across the insights they deem most important on this sheet. Repeat this until all hosts have summarized their insights and all sheets have been dot voted on.

Station topics

1. What should "human-centered AI" look like in your organization? What results or outcomes would you see? What do you hear people say or ask regarding AI?
2. Under what conditions has AI been used in your organization in a manner that supported people?
3. What are examples in your organization where the use of AI was not human-centered, not responsible or not effective, or where could you see it easily sliding down that path?
4. What procedures, rules or processes should be implemented to ensure responsible, human-centered AI use in your organization?
5. What could be measured, tracked or audited to ensure that the way your organization uses AI is responsible and human-centered?



⌚ 5 min

Step 5: Closing

Close the session by thanking everyone for their time, and the station hosts for their gracious facilitation. Reiterate that the anonymous results will be shared with the research initiative, and research updates will be made available on reflexiveai.org.

We recommend going through this checklist:

- Everyone has filled in the informed consent form.
- You have pictures of the outcomes from each station.
- You have collected any notes from station hosts.



Step 6: Send results to us

When you've completed the focus group, please share the following with us to contribute to the research:

- Clear pictures or scans of the station sheets, including dot votes.
- Any notes from the hosts or facilitators on how the session went.
- Any changes that you made to the facilitation format.
- Scans or pictures of filled-in informed consent forms for all participants. Unfortunately, we cannot process data without informed consent.
- Send the materials to info@reflexiveai.org.